CHHATTISGARH

SAI SPREADS HIS WINGS

By Rahul Noronha



WELFARE MANTRA Vishnu Deo Sai blesses a bride during a mass marriage ceremony in Raipur, Nov. 17

Vishnu Deo Sai is finally liberating himself from an image trap that's stalked him ever since he took over as Chhattisgarh chief minister in December 2023. A surprise pick by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) after its unexpected poll victory, observers labelled him "too soft". The only way they read him was via his natural affability, seen as out of alignment with the razor-sharp belligerence of BJP chief ministers like Yogi Adityanath and Himanta Biswa Sarma. Yet, by mid-2024, Sai began to change this narrative. Launching an ambitious outreach programme, he has moved beyond his comfort zone and is leveraging governance to redefine his leadership style. Be it the fight against the Maoists or challenges from within the state BJP, Sai is demonstrating a firm grip on the reins as he completes one year in power.

What stood him in good stead is the delivery on big-ticket promises the BJP had made in the run-up to the state election in 2023. Prominent among these was the Mahtari Vandan Yojana, involving a monthly direct benefit transfer (DBT) of Rs 1,000 each to women who have married, and the payment of Rs 3,100 per quintal—about Rs 900 above the Centre's then minimum support price (MSP)—for paddy procurement. Both these promises have been fulfilled. Also, as promised, tendu cultivators are being paid Rs 5,500 per standard bag of leaves (used for rolling beedis), and funds are being disbursed for the construction of houses under the PM Awas Yojana for the poor. "The previous Congress government did not fulfil even 90 per cent of its promises and people had lost confidence in the system," claims Pankaj Jha, media advisor to the CM. "So, the first priority of the Vishnu Deo Sai government was to restore their faith in democracy."

The welfarist turn has naturally come at a cost, taking a toll on the state's finances. The Mahtari Vandan Yojana, which benefits some 7 million women, alone costs the state Rs 7,900 crore annually. Meanwhile, input subsidies for procuring 14.5 million tonnes paddy in the previous Kharif season amounted to Rs 13,300 crore. This year, the target is to procure 16 MT from almost 2.5 million paddy farmers in the state. As a result, the state has limited room for capital investment, prompting Sai's administration to prioritise revenue generation.

The 2024-25 budget estimates a 21 per cent increase in state's own revenue (SOR), targeting Rs 65,500 crore, without imposing any new taxes. This ambitious plan, say top sources in the government, hinges on increasing excise collections from last year's Rs 8,430 crore to Rs 10,000 crore purely by plugging leakages. Similarly, the government hopes for substantial growth in mining and other non-tax revenue sources, which would leave it with adequate elbow room to finance ambitious projects in the pipeline—for instance, Nava Raipur, a greenfield city that is planned to replace Raipur as the state capital. So is the creation of a Greater Capital Region, covering Durg and Bhilai as well.

CM VISHNU DEO SAI HAS TAKEN A FIRM GRIP OF THE POLITICAL REINS. NOW HE HAS TO FOCUS ON ECONOMIC GROWTH

On the governance front, Sai's new industrial development policy emphasises employment generation while he has also delivered on another pre-poll promise: that of handing over the probe in the Public Service Commission (PSC) recruitment scam to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI). In mid-November, the agency arrested the PSC's former chairman.

Sai's successes are also tied to significant support from the Centre, particularly in the fight against left-wing extremism. Over the past year, Maoist forces have suffered unprec-